

THE BATTLE OF THE SAINTS

Buoyed by their success at Chesapeake Bay, by 1782 the French were on the offensive in the West Indies, hoping to seize control of valuable British colonies. In early April the Comte de Grasse, with 33 ships of the line and two 50-gun ships, escorted a large convoy of merchant ships from Martinique. His mission was to deliver the merchantmen safely to Havana and join with the fleet of France's ally Spain to capture Jamaica. De Grasse was shadowed by the 36 ships of the line of the British fleet under Admiral Sir George Rodney.

On April 9 the two fleets clashed off Dominica. Straining ahead to snap at the heels of the French, the British van, commanded by Admiral Samuel Hood, found itself briefly exposed to attack by de Grasse's entire force. It was an opportunity the French failed to exploit and the exchange ended with one French ship badly shot up. De Grasse's misfortunes continued as he sailed between Dominica and the rocky islets known as the Saintes.



"The Glorious Action"
This gold badge, which belonged to a daughter of King George III, shows the captured French flagship *Ville de Paris* flying the British ensign above the French.

On the night of April 11 the 74-gun *Zélé* collided with de Grasse's flagship *Ville de Paris*. The next morning, seeing Hood launch in pursuit of the crippled *Zélé,* de Grasse came about and gave the order to clear for action.

BREAKING THE LINE

Since Hood needed time to recall his ships, Rodney formed a battle line with his rear division in the van and Hood's division in the rear. Despite this hasty reorganization, the British line was more compact than the straggling line formed by the French. At 7:45 a.m. the exchange of broadsides began, ships passing in opposite directions within musket range. The French came off worst, partly because many of the British guns had been newly equipped with flintlocks.

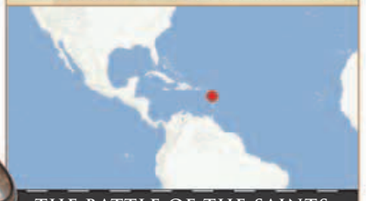
The decisive moment of the battle came at 9:00 a.m. As the wind shifted southerly, Rodney sailed his flagship, the 100-gun *Formidable*, through a gap in the French line, blasting two French ships as he went. As other British ships followed their admiral's example, de Grasse's center division was split into incoherent fragments. The French van, badly knocked about by British broadsides, had sailed clear of the battle and showed little inclination to return. This left Hood free to plunge into the mêlée in the center. The French rear under the Marquis de Vaudreuil made an effort to aid de Grasse, but in vain. The slaughter on the French admiral's flagship was extreme, with some 400 men dead by the time de Grasse struck at 6:00 p.m. His was the fifth French ship to be taken. As darkness fell one of the captured vessels, *César*, was destroyed by a massive explosion.



Commemorative gold ring
The gold and glass intaglio ring bears Rodney's name and the date of the battle of the Saints.

Rodney controversially failed to order a pursuit of the beaten enemy, although two more French ships of the line were taken in the following week. Still, the revenge for the British defeat at Chesapeake was sweet. French aspirations to control the Caribbean were crushed and Rodney's bold breaking of the line—which may not even have been intentional—initiated a new phase in naval tactics.

AMERICAN REVOLUTIONARY WAR



THE BATTLE OF THE SAINTS

Date	April 12, 1782
Location	Between Dominica and Guadeloupe, Caribbean
Result	British victory

COMBATANTS

BRITAIN	FRANCE

COMMANDERS

George Rodney	François Joseph Paul de Grasse

FORCES

Ships: 36 ships of the line	**Ships:** 33 ships of the line

LOSSES

Men: 243 killed, 816 wounded **Ships:** none	**Men:** c.2,000 killed or wounded **Ships:** 5 captured